

IF A LANDLORD TRIES TO BILK YOU:

11. If a landlord tries to hold on to your money, demand an itemized list of the withheld money. Scrutinize it for redundancy. For instance, a landlord can't charge you to clean a carpet and then replace a carpet.

12. Also, when it comes to replacing things, you probably aren't responsible for the entire cost of replacement, unless whatever needs replacing is brand-new and you completely destroyed it.

For example, the useful life of carpeting is generally considered to be seven years. So, if the carpet was brand-new when you moved in, and you ruined it, you're liable for new carpet. On the other hand, if the carpet was five years old when you moved in, and six years old when you moved out, you should only be liable for the amortized value of the carpet. Assuming you *are* responsible for damaging the carpet and it only had one year of useful life left, you should only be on the hook for about 15% of the replacement cost.

Same goes with paint: Was the paint brand-new when you moved in? If not, you shouldn't be paying the full cost of a new paint job.

13. Let's say you get a bill from the landlord, and they are withholding most of your deposit for made-up charges. What do you do? Know your rights. Every state has different laws regarding just how much leeway both renters and landlords are given. Do check your state Attorney General website (NAAG.org) to see what kinds of protections are afforded to you.

14. If you think that the charges are bogus, raise a (polite) fuss. A crooked landlord is going to hope that you simply roll over and let them take your money because so many people do just that. Let them know that you believe the charges to be bogus.

15. Write your complaints down in the form of letters and send copies to an attorney, even if you don't plan to hire an attorney. Send them to your uncle the tax attorney, if you have to. I have a friend who works as an office manager in a law firm that I can send CCs to, if I need to. I address them to her, and she tears them up. Seeing a law firm's name is often enough to get people to back down, because no one wants to deal with a lawyer.

16. Don't let the landlord make you feel petty. If they try say